

WHIDBEY ISLAND HORSE COUNCIL
MEETING MINUTES
9/10/2025

The meeting was called to order at the Race Road Fire station by coordinator Sally Garratt at 6:30pm. Thirteen people were present. Minutes of the last meeting were reviewed and approved.

Leslie discussed the County planning issues that we have been following including the County's Comp Plan. She met with Commissioner Bacon who appeared to be interested in our issues. Leslie advised her that we are proposing an update to the Equine Economic Survey done by the Conservation District in 2015. Leslie suggested that we try to attend the monthly Commissioners meetings to keep the Commissioners aware of our interests.

Connie met with an employee of the Conservation District, Heather McCoy, about the Equine Economic Survey. McCoy suggested that we contact several community members about helping with the survey. A committee was formed to follow up on the survey issue comprised of Connie, Leslie and Jennifer.

Several members had suggestions regarding the Mission Statement for the Horse Council. Leslie will revise the statement and present a final version at the next meeting.

Karena reported that she has looked into the possibility of acquiring the Bell's Farm property for equestrian use. She has reviewed the Easements on the land and reviewed the background regarding the failure of the Bell's farm owners to secure additional land needed for sustainable farming purposes. A lengthy discussion ensued regarding the feasibility of any equestrian use of the property. A committee was formed to look more closely at any possibilities. Members of the committee include Karena, Janet, Kit and Kelly. It was suggested that Erin and Debbie might have relevant information and would be good to include on the committee. Karena will be out of the country for the next Horse Council Meeting so Kit agreed to move forward with this initiative.

Karena brought our attention to an effort in Kitsap County to redefine that county's agricultural code to restrict the ability to have horses boarded on private property. The proposed restrictions would limit the number of horses per acre, restrict where manure could be located, prohibit certain activities and otherwise make horse boarding (or in some cases, horse ownership) difficult if not impossible. That code revision has not been enacted yet but we need to be aware of efforts elsewhere that could restrict the ability to keep horses.

The meeting was adjourned at 8pm. The next meeting will be held on October 8, 2025 at the Race Road Fire Station.